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**Modern British Pronunciation:
Current Tendencies and American Influence**

Bachelor's Thesis

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Declaration

“I hereby declare that I have worked on this Bachelor’s thesis on my own and that all the information used in the thesis has been fully acknowledged in the text and included in the list of references.”

Brno 11 April

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Abstract

The influence of American English is enormous. Hence, it is suggested that it has an impact on British English on the level of syntax, morphology and even pronunciation.

This Bachelor's thesis focuses on the modern form of non-regional British pronunciation and examines the current tendencies in it. The aim of the thesis is to find out whether it is influenced by the American pronunciation and to what extent.

The thesis consists of Theoretical and Analytical part. Theoretical part provides information connected to the topic; it, therefore, discusses typical features of both accents as well as their mutual comparison. Analytical part looks into the recordings of two British speakers with a special regard to the progressiveness of their pronunciation. Finally, the research findings are presented.

Key words

accent, dialect, Received Pronunciation, Standard Southern British Pronunciation, General American Pronunciation, American influence

Anotace

Vliv americké angličtiny je ohromný. Existují tedy názory, že americká angličtina ovlivňuje tu britskou z hlediska syntaxe, morfologie ale také výslovnosti.

Tato bakalářská práce se zaměřuje na moderní podobu britské neregionální výslovnosti a zkoumá její aktuální trendy. Hlavním cílem této práce je zjistit, zda je britská výslovnost ovlivněna tou americkou a v jakém rozsahu.

Práce se skládá z části teoretické a analytické. Teoretická část obsahuje informace týkající se tématu. Zkoumá tedy britskou a americkou výslovnost a vzájemně je porovnává. V analytické části jsou rozebrány nahrávky dvou britských mluvčích se zvláštním ohledem na modernost jejich výslovnosti. V závěrečné části jsou prezentovány výsledky výzkumu.

Klíčová slova

akcent, dialekt, spisovná anglická výslovnost, spisovná americká výslovnost, americký vliv

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Introduction

In 1607 when the first colony on the new continent was established it was the United Kingdom that was in a superior position in relation to America. However, the situation has changed over the last two centuries and the United States of America have become one of the most influential and powerful countries in the whole world. Nowadays, they influence the world not only with its political power but also with the power of its media and culture, the American film industry being perhaps the most prolific one. Moreover, most people including the British are exposed to it on a daily basis as there are hundreds of American series and films on TV. It is impossible for the British film industry to rival the American one. Thus, it is likely to hear American English even on British TV channels.

The fact that American English is the dominant one suggests that it has an impact on British English on the level of syntax, morphology and even pronunciation. The thesis examines the modern form of the British pronunciation and the current tendencies, which are, in some aspects, bringing the British pronunciation nearer to the American one. The aim of this thesis is to find out whether the influence of American English, to which even the British people are exposed to a large extent, is reflected in their own pronunciation. The primary research question is: Does the exposure to the American spoken language affect the pronunciation of British people? More precisely, are there any features of the American pronunciation in their accent?

The thesis is divided into two parts. Theoretical part describes British and American pronunciation and discusses their differences and current changes with special regard to the influence of the American pronunciation on the British. The thesis opens with the basic terminology such as accent or dialect and then continues with investigating the differentness of the varieties of the English language in the world. Consequently, the traditional description of the British pronunciation is offered. Moreover, the current tendencies, which are taking place in the British pronunciation, are discussed. Finally, the American pronunciation is defined and compared with the modern British pronunciation. In addition, a chapter concerning the impact of the American English and American media, is added, including information about their influence on the British English in terms of grammar and vocabulary.

In Analytical part, the speeches of two different British speakers are observed and, subsequently, analysed. The aim of Analytical part is to find out whether the phenomena described in Theoretical part are noticeable in their speech. The research carries on with the comparison of the two speakers. Eventually, the results of Analytical part are presented, based on which, the conclusion is made.

THEORETICAL PART

1 British and American pronunciation

Since the foundation of the first American colony in the 17th century, American and British English began to develop separately and today represent two different dialects of the English language. At this point it is important to cover the distinction of the two terms ‘accent’ and ‘dialect’. Roach (1991: 4) and Trudgill (1974: 17) agree that the term dialect refers to a variety of language which is different from others in vocabulary, grammar and pronunciation. On the other hand, the term accent refers to a pronunciation variety only. Based on this explanation it can be said that American and British English are two different dialects since they are different on the level of pronunciation as well as on the level of grammar and vocabulary.

Trudgill and Hannah (2017: 12-13) claim that there are three main reasons why English outside of England particularly in America resulted in being noticeably different from English in its actual home country. The first reason is a linguistic change. As every language develops through time it is obvious that some changes have taken place in Britain whereas different changes in America. Regarding a linguistic change, Wells (1982: 94) explains the ‘principle of least effort’ that people tend to follow in a language. It simply means that where “a simple articulatory gesture works as well as a complex one, there is a natural tendency to prefer it” (ibid.). Another important factor, especially regarding the American English, is language contact. American settlers came into contact not only with languages of indigenous American inhabitants but also with languages of other European settlers coming, for example, from Spain or France. The last reason suggested is dialect contact. In the new colonies people from different corners of the United Kingdom got in touch, thus features of certain dialects and accents began to affect one another and in a couple of generations new varieties of the English language were born.

For the purposes of this thesis three model accents were chosen. These are Received Pronunciation (RP) and its modern form Standard Southern British Pronunciation (SSB) as the representatives of the British pronunciation and General American (GA) as a representative of the American pronunciation. Although there are only 3-5 % of people in the UK speaking RP (Trudgill & Hannah 2017: 4) and supposedly SSB, it is – according to Roach (1991: 5) – one of the most described British accents and

remains the model accent for teaching pronunciation to EFL students. On the contrary, General American Pronunciation is an accent spoken by number of Americans and as well as RP or SSB is a model accent for EFL students willing to acquire American pronunciation. These three accents will be further described in the following chapters. Of course, there are many other British and American regional accents, but these will not be discussed in the thesis.

2 Received Pronunciation and Standard Southern British

2.1 Birth of Received Pronunciation

Received Pronunciation or shortly RP is a prestige British accent, also sometimes referred to as ‘BBC English’ or the ‘Queen’s English’. It has its roots in the 19th century when people of the upper classes all over the UK started to adopt the pronunciation of the upper classes in London and surrounding areas (Lindsey 2019: 1). It was the British public schools where the majority of RP speakers studied, which played an important part in the adoption of RP (ibid.). Eventually, in the 20th century the BBC adopted this accent as a standard for their reporters and became a very important medium in transmitting RP not only to those of the upper classes but directly to the general public that was not exposed to this accent before (Cruttenden 2014: 77).

2.2 Birth of Standard Southern British Pronunciation

The domination of RP in media and public life started to reverse in 1960s. As the British society began to be more liberal and egalitarian, “social privileges connected with RP were no longer seen as prestigious but rather as unfair” and speakers of RP started to be considered snobbish or posh (Lindsey 2019: 3).

Nowadays, RP is no longer a necessity for people to hold certain posts as it used to be in the past (Trudgill & Hannah 2017: 21). The BBC is employing a number of announcers with non-RP accents (Collins & Mees 2013: 4) and it is suggested that today’s society has a more egalitarian view on regional accents. Nevertheless, RP has not died out but rather transformed into a different form. The term Received Pronunciation is perceived as outdated by public, a symbol of the past and the supremacy of the upper classes. Therefore, Wells (1982: 117) suggests that the term Standard Southern British Pronunciation (SSB) should be used instead of RP today. Lindsey (2019: 4) points out that SSB has much in common with RP as it is an accent spoken particularly by middle and upper-middle classes in the south of England. According to Collins and Mees (2013: 4) it can be often “heard from educated middle and younger generation speakers in England who have a pronunciation which cannot be pinned down to a specific area”. Moreover, it is an accent which is often heard in public life or on TV.

In the following part of the thesis, the vowel and consonant system of SSB will be described. The term SSB is still not well-established; therefore, there are no detailed

descriptions of the SSB vowel and consonant system. However, there are no big systematic differences between RP and SSB. For this reason, in the following subchapters, the traditional description of RP vowel and consonant system is used.

To describe the concrete vowels, keywords from the standard lexical sets designed by Wells (1982: 123) are used. Each one of the keywords describes a single vowel in the traditional RP and GA vowel system as can be seen in Figure 1.

keyword	RP	GA	keyword	RP	GA
KIT	ɪ	ɪ	THOUGHT	ɔ:	ɔ
DRESS	e	ɛ	GOAT	əʊ	oʊ
TRAP	æ	æ	GOOSE	u:	u
LOT	ɒ	ɑ	PRICE	aɪ	aɪ
STRUT	ʌ	ʌ	CHOICE	ɔɪ	ɔɪ
FOOT	ʊ	ʊ	MOUTH	aʊ	aʊ
BATH	ɑ:	æ	NEAR	ɪə	ɪr
CLOTH	ɒ	ɔ	SQUARE	ɛə	ɛr
NURSE	ɜ:	ɜr	START	ɑ:	ɑr
FLEECE	i:	i	NORTH	ɔ:	ɔr
FACE	eɪ	eɪ	FORCE	ɔ:	or
PALM	ɑ:	ɑ	CURE	ʊə	ʊr

Figure 1 Standard Lexical Sets (Wells 1982: 123)

2.3 Vowel system

Vowels are sounds produced with no obstructions to the airflow (Roach 1991: 10). Individual vowels differ one from another by shape and position of tongue while pronouncing them (ibid.: 11). Based on the changing position and shape of tongue, vowels can be front, central or back and open or close (ibid.: 13). Another criterium of division is lip-rounding. According to the position and shape of lips, vowels can be rounded, spread or neutral (ibid.: 14).

There are nineteen vowels in the RP and SSB vowel system, not including the schwa /ə/, which is different from the other vowels. They can be divided into six short (/ɪ/, /e/, /æ/, /ʌ/, /ɒ/, /ʊ/) and five long monophthongs (/i:/, /ɜ:/, /ɑ:/, /ɔ:/, /u:/) which are different in length but also in quality (Roach 1991: 14-18).

Other groups would be eight diphthongs and five triphthongs which consist of two or three vowels and are pronounced by a movement from one to another. The diphthongs

can be divided into three centring (/ɪə/, /eə/, /ʊə/) and five closing (/eɪ/, /aɪ/, /ɔɪ/, /əʊ/, /aʊ/) according to whether they end in /ə/, /ɪ/ or /ʊ/. The rule which applies to all the diphthongs is that the first part of it is much longer and stronger than the second part (Roach 1991: 20-24).

2.4 Current tendencies in pronunciation of vowels

Authors such as Trudgill and Hannah (2017) or Upton and Kretzschmar (2017) describe some changes which are currently taking place in RP. Particularly in ‘advanced’ or ‘unmarked’ RP spoken especially by younger speakers, which is the opposite to ‘conservative’ or ‘marked’ RP spoken mainly by older speakers. Lindsey (2019) or Collins and Mess (2013), on the other hand, consider the same or similar phenomena of the current SSB pronunciation. Therefore, the accent which some authors perceive as advanced RP whereas others as SSB pronunciation is more or less the same. This means that what some authors may still refer to as ‘modern’ or advanced RP, others may define as SSB, which may sometimes cause confusions and problems with terminology. This fact confirms that the term SSB is quite new and not adopted by all the authors yet.

In this thesis, in order to prevent problems with terminology, Lindsey’s approach to this issue will be applied. Hence, the term SSB will be used to refer to modern British pronunciation whereas the term RP to refer to the old form of British pronunciation. In the next few subchapters some phenomena which differentiate modern SSB from traditional RP in terms of vowels will be described.

2.4.1 New system

The symbols listed in Chapter 2.3 are used in the majority of dictionaries such as Cambridge, Oxford, Longman or Collins and in literature by a number of authors to refer to RP as well as SSB. However, in some dictionaries different symbols are used in case of some vowels. For instance, the *Routledge Dictionary of Pronunciation for Current English* (Upton & Kretzschmar 2017), which claims to be “the most up-to-date record of the pronunciation of British and American English” (ibid.: 2), provides symbols different from the ones in the dictionaries mentioned above. Instead of /e/, /æ/, /eə/, /ɜ:/, /aɪ/ the symbols /ɛ/, /a/, /ɛ:/, /ə:/, /ʌ/ are used for British English, respectively.

According to Wells (as mentioned in Lindsey 2019: v), traditional descriptions of RP do not reflect the current form of the modern British pronunciation. Consequently, the traditional system of symbols is no longer appropriate. For this reason, Lindsey (2019)

goes even further and introduces a new vowel chart for SSB with new categorization and some new symbols replacing the traditional ones. For the purposes of the comparison there are the traditional RP symbols in light grey and the black symbols referring to the modern SSB pronunciation next to each other.

short-lax			long-tense					
			linking-r vowels			diphthongs (free)		
KIT	I		NEAR	I:	Iə	FLEECE	Ij	i:
DRESS	ɛ	e	SQUARE	ɛ:	eə	FACE	ɛj	eɪ
LOT	ɔ	ɒ	THOUGHT	o:	ɔ:	CHOICE	oj	ɔɪ
TRAP	a	æ	PALM	ɑ:		PRICE	ɑj	aɪ
FOOT	ə	ʊ	(CURE	ə:	ʊə)			
STRUT	ʌ		NURSE	ə:	ɜ:			
	comma	ə				MOUTH	aw	aʊ
						GOOSE	ɰw	u:
						GOAT	əw	əʊ

Figure 2 Vowel Chart for the CUBE Dictionary (Lindsey 2019: 146)

In this thesis traditional symbols will be used primarily, as they are still used in the majority of dictionaries. Nevertheless, for the purpose of the comparison the new symbols used either in the *CUBE Dictionary* (Lindsey & Szigetvári) or in the *Routledge Dictionary of Pronunciation for Current English* (Upton & Kretzschmar 2017) will be mentioned, too. The traditional symbols can be seen in Figure 3.

ɪ:	I	ʊ	u:	Iə	eɪ	ɔ:	X
e	ə	ɜ:	ɔ:	ʊə	ɔɪ	əʊ	
æ	ʌ	ɑ:	ɒ	eə	aɪ	aʊ	
P	b	t	d	tʃ	dʒ	k	g
f	v	θ	ð	s	z	ʃ	ʒ
m	n	ŋ	h	l	r	w	j

Figure 3 RP, SSB Phonemic Chart (Underhill 2005: viii)

2.4.2 Smoothing

In general, there is a tendency for diphthongs to become monophthongs in SSB (Lindsey 2019: 47). Especially long monophthongs can be heard instead of the centring diphthongs (ibid.). This process called ‘smoothing’ simply creates a long monophthong out of the first sound of the diphthong. Hence, /ɪə/ in *near* or *here* may become /ɪ:/ sound and /eə/ in *square*, *wear* or *there* may become a long open sound /ɛ:/. Trudgill and Hannah (2017: 16) even assume that the monophthongised /ɛ:/ “is becoming rather more open amongst younger speakers, moving somewhat in the direction of /æ:/”. The same applies to triphthongs, therefore, /aʊə/ in *tower* may be, in some instances, pronounced as /ɑ:/.

Monophthongisation of the three centring diphthongs is reflected, for example, in the *CUBE Dictionary* (Lindsey & Szigetvári) or in the *Routledge Dictionary of Pronunciation for Current English* (Upton & Kretzschmar 2017) where the symbols /ɛ:/ and /ɪ:/ are used.

It should be mentioned that the centring diphthongs still exist and are used. The symbols /eə/, /ɪə/ and /ʊə/ are given in the *Cambridge English Pronouncing Dictionary* (Jones 2006) or in the *Longman Pronunciation Dictionary* (Wells 2000) to refer to the SQUARE, NEAR and CURE vowel. An exception would be words where the “smoothed” form is already deep-seated in the majority of Britons. For instance, *sure* and *poor* are transcribed with /ɔ:/ instead of /ʊə/ even in the *Cambridge English Pronouncing Dictionary* (Jones 2006).

2.4.3 happY and thank YOU vowel

Nowadays, in SSB the KIT vowel /ɪ/ and the FOOT vowel /ʊ/ are used only before consonants (Lindsey 2019: 31, 36). The use of KIT and FOOT immediately before a vowel or at the end of some words is seen as old-fashioned (ibid.) or even archaic (Collins & Mees 2013: 104). In case of FOOT, it is being replaced by a vowel similar to GOOSE /u:/. Instead of KIT a vowel similar to FLEECE /i:/, which is known as the ‘happY vowel’, is used which is a process known as ‘happy tensing’.

A few decades ago, when KIT and FOOT started being replaced, the symbols /ɪ/ and /ʊ/ were adopted to indicate the change. It was suggested that older speakers used rather /ɪ/ and /ʊ/ and younger speakers /i:/ and /u:/ (Lindsey 2019: 32, 36). Therefore, the symbols describing these phenomena were something between it. As Collins and Meer (2013: 104) put it, “the happY vowel is short like KIT but close like FLEECE”.

On the other hand, some authors such as Wells (2012) or Lindsey (2019: 32, 36), nowadays, refuse the use of the symbols /i/ and /u/. Wells (2012) states that “It seemed like a good idea at the time, but it clearly confuses a lot of people.” As a result, they suggest using rather the symbols for the FLEECE and GOOSE vowels – /i:/ and /u:/. However, the traditional transcriptions with /i/ and /u/ can be found in most dictionaries. Thus, *happy* and *thank you* are mostly described as /'hæpi/ and /'θæŋk ju/ as, for instance, in the *Cambridge English Pronouncing Dictionary* (Jones 2006). However, surprisingly, the Cambridge Dictionary online uses the symbol for the GOOSE vowel in *thank you*, therefore /'θæŋk ju:/.

2.4.4 Weak Vowel Merger

To summarize, the KIT and FOOT vowels are used only when a consonant follows; however, there is a tendency for them to be replaced by the schwa (Lindsey 2019: 39). Being more advanced in words with the FOOT preceded by /j/ (ibid.), this phenomenon is known as ‘weak vowel merger’ and is typical of the American English (Wells 1982: 167). Accordingly, words such as *ambulance* or *education* may be pronounced with /jə/ instead of /jʊ/.

2.4.5 TRAP replacing PALM

In the 18th century the process which is referred to as ‘BATH-broadening’ started in RP (Lindsey 2019: 41). In so-called ‘BATH-words’ where the TRAP vowel was used in RP as well as in GA, the PALM vowel started to be used in RP. Therefore, the words such as *bath*, *answer* or *after* were pronounced with long /ɑ:/ instead of short /æ/. Nowadays, in SSB the unbroadened TRAP can be heard instead of PALM in *mass*, *pasta* or *transfer*. In addition, Lindsey (2019: 42) even claims that “it is now common to have unbroadened TRAP in *bath*, *after*, *ask*”. That is not, however, standard pronunciation displayed in dictionaries.

2.4.6 LOT replacing THOUGHT

In SSB the LOT vowel /ɒ/ is more common than in RP as it is replacing the THOUGHT vowel in words such as *false* or *salt* (Lindsey 2019: 30). In case of *false* and *salt*, the transcription with /ɒ/ is used even in the *Cambridge English Pronouncing Dictionary* (Jones 2006) as the only pronunciation possible and in the *Routledge*

Dictionary of Pronunciation for Current English (Upton & Kretzschmar 2017) as a possible variant.

2.5 Consonant system

In contrast to vowels, during the production of consonants the airflow meets an obstruction on its way. There are 24 consonants in RP and SSB, which can be divided into several groups according to the place of articulation, manner of articulation and whether they are voiced or unvoiced. The division can be seen in Figure 4.

		Place of articulation							
		Bilabial	Labiodental	Dental	Alveolar	Palato-alveolar (Post-alveolar)	Palatal	Velar	Glottal
Manner of articulation	Plosive	p b			t d			k g	
	Fricative		f v	θ ð	s z	ʃ ʒ			h
	Affricate					tʃ dʒ			
	Nasal	m			n			ŋ	
	Lateral approximant				L				
		w				r	j		

Figure 4 Chart of English consonant phonemes (Roach 1991: 62)

2.5.1 Plosives

The first group are plosives. During the production of plosives “articulators are moved against each other, so as to form a total stricture that allows no air to escape from the vocal tract” (Roach 1991: 30). Finally, there is a plosion which releases the air.

There are six plosives in English, three of them being unvoiced /p/, /t/, /k/ and three of them voiced /b/, /d/, /g/. Also, they differ in a place of articulation. /p/ and /b/ are bilabial, so that the lips are pressed together while producing them. /t/ and /d/ are alveolar, pronounced with the tip of tongue touching the alveolar ridge and, finally, /k/ and /g/ are velar, so that the back of tongue presses the area between soft and hard palate while their production. (Roach 1991: 30-32).

Two terms ‘fortis’ and ‘lenis’ are used in connection to English voiced and unvoiced. As /p/, t/ and /k/ are produced with more force, they are called fortis and /b/, /d/, /g/ produced less strongly are then called lenis. The same applies for other consonants (Roach 1991: 33).

2.5.2 Fricatives and affricates

When producing fricatives, the air flow escapes through a small space between articulators and “makes a hissing sound” (Roach 1991: 47). In total there are nine fricatives in English (Roach 1991: 62). /f/ and /v/ are labiodental which means that the upper teeth touch the lower lip during their production. /θ/ and /ð/ are dental, so that they are pronounced with the tip of tongue touching the upper teeth. Post-alveolar /ʃ/ and /ʒ/ are produced with tongue being in contact with an area behind an alveolar ridge. Finally, /h/ is pronounced in the vocal folds as a glottal sound.

The affricates /tʃ/ and /dʒ/ are a combination of plosives and fricatives. Thus, they begin as plosives and end as fricatives (Roach 1991: 52).

2.5.3 Nasals, /l/ and /r/

The three nasal consonants /m/, /n/ and /ŋ/ are pronounced with lowered soft palate which allows the air flow to escape through nose (Roach 1991: 56).

/l/ is a lateral consonant. The tip of tongue touches the alveolar ridge which makes it impossible for the air to escape the usual way. Therefore, the air goes out along both sides of tongue (Roach 1991: 58).

During an articulation of a post-alveolar approximant /r/, “articulators approach each other but do not get sufficiently close to each other to produce a complete consonant” (Roach 1991: 59).

2.6 Current tendencies in pronunciation of consonants

Although there are not so many current tendencies concerning consonants in comparison to vowels, there are still quite a few, which deserve attention. These will be described in the following subchapters.

2.6.1 Aspiration

Aspiration is an articulation of voiceless plosives with an audible sound of air, “typically creating an /h/-like whisper” (Lindsey 2019: 55). The sounds /p/, /t/ and /k/ are aspirated in RP as well as in SSB where the aspiration is even stronger (ibid.). Short or weak aspiration is seen as old-fashioned (ibid.).

2.6.2 Yod-dropping and yod-coalescence

There are two possible pronunciations of words such as *suit* or *super*. It may be pronounced either as /su:t/ or /sju:t/ but a preferable pronunciation among younger speakers is with the omission of /j/, which is called ‘yod-dropping’ (Trudgill & Hannah 2017: 16) and is typical of the American English (Collins & Mees 2013: 96, Cruttenden 2014: 84).

A similar process known as ‘yod-coalescence’ is taking place in words such as *Tuesday* or *education*. There is a tendency for the consonant cluster /tj/ and /dj/ to become more of an affricate consonant /tʃ/ and /dʒ/ (Collins & Mees 2013: 96). Yod-coalescence appears not only within words but also “across word boundaries” (ibid.) in *can’t you* or *did you*. This pronunciation is now very common despite the fact that in the 1980s it was “felt to be rather vulgar” according to Wells (as cited in Lindsey 2019: 59). Even nowadays it can be perceived as lazy speech by some older speakers (Collins & Mees 2013: 96).

2.6.3 Glottal stop and /t/-voicing

In SSB the ‘glottal stop’ is a standard pronunciation of /t/ before a consonant for many speakers, in words such as *fooʔball*, *deparʔment*, *neʔwork*, in comparison to RP where the glottal stop was avoided as it was a characteristic feature of London’s working class accent ‘Cockney’ (Lindsey 2019: 67). Not only can it occur word-internally before a consonant but also before an unstressed vowel as in *Briʔish*, *ciʔy* or *waʔer* (ibid.: 68). Furthermore, it can be used word-finally before a consonant as well as before a vowel, for instance, in *Greaʔ Britain*, *geʔready* or *geʔout* (ibid.: 67, 68).

To sum up, the word-internal and word-final use of the glottal stop is quite common before a consonant in contrast to its use before a vowel where it is considered less standard (Lindsey 2019: 67, 68). However, Collins and Mees (2013: 75) suggest that the use of the glottal stop is in general restricted rather to informal than formal situations.

Another way to pronounce /t/ typical mainly of the American pronunciation is as the sound similar to /d/. This phenomenon is called ‘/t/-voicing’ and is quite common in words such as *got*, *it*, *what*, *get out* or *put it away* (Lindsey 2019: 69; Collins & Mees 2013: 205).

2.6.4 G-dropping

‘G-dropping’ is a pronunciation of the weak ending *-ing* as /ɪn/ instead of the standard /ɪŋ/. This pronunciation is widely considered incorrect; however, it can be heard from some British speakers; nevertheless, it is more likely to be heard from American speakers (Lindsey 2019: 73).

2.6.5 Intrusive r

‘Linking r’ corresponds to *r* in the spelling, whereas ‘intrusive r’ does not. RP distinguished between linking and intrusive *r*, which was not accepted as standard (Lindsey 2019: 87). This is not the case of SSB. Nowadays, intrusive *r* is used especially after schwa, the PALM vowel and the THOUGHT vowel regardless of whether it is in spelling or not (ibid.). Therefore, it is very common to hear *China/r/ and, law/r/ and order* or *vanilla/r/ ice*. Nevertheless, it can be considered as “lazy or uneducated speech” by older generations (Collins & Mees 2013: 124).

3 General American Pronunciation

According to Wells (1982: 470) General American pronunciation is a group of closely related accents which “do not show marked eastern or southern characteristics”. Unlike RP, GA is not a prestige accent but rather a social accent spoken by educated Americans through the USA (Carley & Mees 2020: 5). Similarly to SSB, GA is an accent widely heard from TV and radio announcers, hence, it is sometimes called Network English (ibid.: 6).

In the following chapter the contrasts between SSB and GA will be further described.

4 SSB and GA compared

Some of the differences mentioned in this chapter were already briefly discussed while describing the differences between RP and SSB in Chapter 2. In this chapter they will be compared with the American pronunciation and discussed in more detail. For the purposes of comparison, Figure 5 and Figure 6 representing the phonemic chart for SSB and GA are added, respectively.

ɪ	ɪ	ʊ	u	ɪə	eɪ	ɔː	ʌ
e	ə	ɜː	ɔː	ʊə	ɔɪ	əʊ	
æ	ʌ	ɑː	ɒ	eə	aɪ	aʊ	
p	b	t	d	tʃ	dʒ	k	g
f	v	θ	ð	s	z	ʃ	ʒ
m	n	ŋ	h	l	r	w	j

Figure 5 RP, SSB Phonemic Chart (Underhill 2005: viii)

ɪ	ɪ	ʊ	u	eɪ	ɔː	ʌ	ɔː
e	ə	ɜː	ɔː	ɔɪ	əʊ		
æ	ʌ	ɑː		aɪ	aʊ		
p	b	t	d	tʃ	dʒ	k	g
f	v	θ	ð	s	z	ʃ	ʒ
m	n	ŋ	h	l	r	w	j

Figure 6 GA Phonemic Chart (Underhill)

4.1 Vowel systems compared

The consonant system of GA is more or less the same as the one of RP and SSB. However, the vowel system shows more differences.

4.1.1 PALM /ɑː/ X TRAP /æ/

Generally, there is the PALM vowel used in some words in RP and SSB, whereas the TRAP vowel is used in GA. In the 18th century, the process known as BATH-broadening, already described in Chapter 2, caused words such as *bath*, *answer* or *demand* to be pronounced with an open, back vowel /ɑː/ in RP, in contrast to an open, front vowel /æ/ in GA (Lindsey 2019: 41). This is traditionally considered to be one of the distinctive features of the British and American pronunciation.

Nonetheless, nowadays, according to Lindsey (2019: 42), this difference fades away in modern SSB. In other words, it is possible to hear some speakers using unbroadened TRAP in words where PALM would be used a few years ago. Lindsey (2019: 42) even points out that the TRAP vowel is in SSB used in words such as *ask*, *bath* or *demand*. Based on my personal research done on the YouGlish site when 30 recordings

of the word *demand* being said by different Britons were compared, 5 out of 30 used a vowel somewhat between /ɑ:/ and /æ/ and only one the distinct vowel /æ/. The one being Sir Kenneth Robinson on his TEDx talk in London. This fact may suggest that there really is a tendency for some BATH-words to be pronounced with /æ/ instead of /ɑ:/. However, for now, it stays one of the distinctive features between GA and SSB, as displayed in dictionaries.

4.1.2 LOT /ɒ/ X /ɑ/

Another difference in pronunciation being the LOT, which in RP and SSB contains a vowel completely different from the one in GA. In RP it is composed of a nearly open, back, rounded vowel /ɒ/ (Wells 1982: 130). Since this sound is not used in GA it has a fully open, central, unrounded vowel /ɑ/ (ibid.). It is suggested that the LOT vowel in SSB is less open, nowadays, therefore, it is becoming rather /ɔ/ (Lindsey 2019: 29). Yet, a sound still very distinct from the American /ɑ/.

4.1.3 GOAT /əʊ/ X /oʊ/

While in RP the GOAT diphthong contains the schwa and /ʊ/, in GA it consists of a back half-close rounded /o/ and /ʊ/ (Wells 1982: 146). This diphthong occurs in words such as *goat*, *boat* or *local*.

In Chapter 2 the replacement of the THOUGHT vowel by the LOT vowel in some words in SSB is discussed. Moreover, LOT is replacing the schwa of the first part of the GOAT diphthong for some SSB speakers, bringing SSB nearer to GA (Lindsey 2019: 30). Therefore, in words such as *control*, *cold* or *hole* it is quite common for some SSB speakers to say /oʊ/ or perhaps /əʊ/ instead of /əʊ/. Which is again typically American pronunciation of this diphthong. This change of the GOAT is offered, for instance, in the Collins Dictionary online.

In addition, Collins and Mees (2013: 159) point out that the use of /əʊ/ instead of /oʊ/ by younger generation of Americans can be observed, nowadays.

Given the above, it can be concluded that in the case of the GOAT diphthong, some SSB speakers prefer the typical American pronunciation of it and, correspondingly, some GA speakers prefer the typical British pronunciation. To clarify the pronunciation of the GOAT vowel, its GA and SSB transcription in four online dictionaries can be seen in Figure 7.

	SSB	GA
Cambridge	/gəʊt/	/gout/
Oxford	/gəʊt/	/gəʊt/
Longman	/gəʊt/	/gout/
Collins	/gout/	x

Figure 7 GOAT vowel in online dictionaries

4.1.4 Weak Vowel Merger

In RP the KIT and the FOOT vowels were very often used in weak syllables before consonants (Lindsey 2019: 39). However, there is a tendency for these vowels to be replaced by the schwa (ibid.). In particular, it is quite common in words where there is a /j/ sound before the FOOT vowel (ibid.). Thus, words such as *ambulance*, *education* or *particular* are likely to be pronounced with /jə/. This phenomenon is called weak vowel merger and is typical of the American English, where it is more advanced (Wells 1982: 167). The well-known example of weak vowel merger being the interchangeability of *roses* and *Rosa's* both pronounced with schwa in GA and by some SSB speakers.

4.2 Consonant systems compared

4.2.1 Yod-dropping

In words such as *suit*, *supermarket* or *supervise* there would be an alveolar consonant /s/ followed by /j/ in RP (Trudgill & Hannah 2017: 16). In SSB yod disappeared from most of such words, except for *assume* or *pursue*, where most speakers retain it (ibid.). For GA, pronunciation without /j/ is typical (ibid.).

4.2.2 /t/-voicing and tapping

/t/-voicing and ‘tapping’ are two phenomena well established in GA. Tapping is a pronunciation of *t* in unstressed syllables as a “rapid tap rather than a more deliberate plosive” (Wells 1982: 248). /t/-voicing, as the name suggests, is a pronunciation of *t* as a rather voiced than unvoiced consonant. Together they make the American pronunciation of *t* sound more like /d/ which “leads to neutralisation of the contrast /t – d/” (Collins & Mees 2013: 158). Thus, pairs of words such as *heating* and *heeding* or *metal* and *medal* sound almost the same or the same. In transcription, such pronunciation of *t* is marked as /ɾ/ (Collins & Mees 2013: 158).

In RP this pronunciation of *t* was not permitted. However, in today's SSB it can be heard in some words, phrases or phrasal and prepositional verbs such as *British*, *pretty*, *lot of*, *not only*, *but also*, *put it away* or *what else* (Lindsey 2019: 69).

4.2.3 G-dropping

G-dropping is a pronunciation of *-ing* as /ɪn/ instead of /ɪŋ/ (Collins & Mees 2013: 203). This pronunciation is considered incorrect in GA as well as in SSB and RP despite the fact that it used to be a common feature of the aristocratic speech (Lindsey 2019: 73). Nonetheless, it is rather an American phenomenon, which can also be heard in SSB (ibid.). Wells (1982: 263) points out that while in Birmingham, England even the working class uses rather velar /ŋ/ than /n/, in Birmingham, Alabama the alveolar /n/ infects middle-class and educated speech.

4.2.4 Rhoticity and non-rhoticity

'Rhoticity' of GA and 'non-rhoticity' of RP and SSB is perhaps the most noticeable difference between these two accents. In RP, SSB as well as in GA /r/ is a post-alveolar approximant (Roach 1991: 51). In case of RP and SSB the pronunciation of /r/ is realized only when occurring before a vowel, whereas in GA it is pronounced even in a final position and before consonants (Carley & Mees 2020: 132).

Originally /r/ was a "strong trill formed by allowing the tip of the tongue to vibrate or flutter against the upper gums while voiced breath was forced out under moderately strong pressure" (Thomas 1958: 86). This type of /r/ is still preserved in some Scottish varieties of English (ibid.). Since such a production of /r/ required a great amount of energy, /r/ was gradually weakened to become a post-alveolar approximant (ibid.). Eventually, it was omitted in a final position and before consonants in the south of England and some parts of America (Collins & Mees 2013: 189). The loss of rhoticity spread to RP from London working class' speech Cockney in the 18th century (Trudgill & Hannah 2017: 21). Thomas (1958: 89) estimates that approximately three-quarters of the Americans have rhotic accent.

The lack of the centring diphthongs /ɪə/, /eə/, /ʊə/ in GA is related to its rhoticity. Instead of these diphthongs, there are /ɪr/, /er/, /ʊr/ (Wells 1982: 123). Although the three centring diphthongs are not used by SSB speakers as much as by RP speakers and for some SSB speakers may be replaced by /ɪ:/, /e:/ and /ʊ:/ (Lindsey 2019: 47), SSB retains non-rhoticity as its typical feature.

5 Dominance of American English

5.1 British TV¹

As already mentioned in Introduction, the exposure to the American English is enormous due to the media. Comparing the population of the UK and the USA, it is obvious that Britain with its nearly 70 million inhabitants cannot have such a cultural output as America with more than 300 million inhabitants.

British TV is full of American films and TV shows. Concerning American series, Channel 4 a public-service television network, the second most watched channel in the UK in the third quarter of 2019 (Stoll 2021), offers at least a few episodes of *The Simpsons* every day. Channel 5, the fourth most watched channel (ibid.), broadcasts at least seven episodes of *Friends* during a weekend. ITV 2 disposes of *The Ellen DeGeneres Show*, *Family Guy*, *American Dad!* and other shows. Heaven on Earth for those who love American series would perhaps be Channel E4 owned by Channel 4 aimed at those in their 20s or 30s. The programme of E4 includes *The Big Bang Theory*, *The Goldbergs*, *Brooklyn Nine-Nine* being broadcast nearly all day long. On the other hand, BBC 1, Britain's most watched channel (ibid.), appears to be quite immune to American influence as most of its programming is British. Nevertheless, American English can be heard on BBC 1, too. *The Graham Norton Show*, a comedy talk show from 2007 hosted by a presenter Graham Norton, who invites a number of famous Americans, can be the proof.

American films are broadcast on all of these channels as well as on BBC 2 or ITV even in peak times. An interesting current phenomenon to which attention is devoted for last few years is the appearance of British actors in American films. It is very common for British actors to reach fame over the Atlantic Ocean in Hollywood. There are several reasons for that. Firstly, British actors are well-trained in an art of acting including a voice training and seem to have no problem with imitating the American accent. Secondly, they represent unknown fresh faces for the American audience. Last but not least, they have the same qualities as big American stars; however, they may be cheaper (Thorpe 2015). Thus, even though there are British actors in American films, they play Americans, so they speak with American accent.

¹ The data about programmes being aired on certain British TV channels are based on my personal research in February 2021.

To conclude the American production appearing on British TV channels is tremendous and it takes a lot of effort to absolutely avoid it. Therefore, almost everyone who watches TV on regular basis may be exposed to it to some extent.

5.2 Americanization of British English

This thesis examines the American influence on British English in terms of pronunciation. Therefore, other areas of language do not get much space in it. Nevertheless, the Americanization of grammar and vocabulary is perhaps even bigger issue and should be at least mentioned.

5.2.1 Vocabulary

Concerning vocabulary, many words which were a few years ago perceived as distinctively American are nowadays frequently used in British English. Lindsey (2019: 12) mentions words such as *awesome*, *movie*, *cool* (meaning good) or *multiple* (instead of numerous, many) are used very often by British speakers.

Anderson (2017) in her article for BBC Culture called *How Americanisms are killing the English language* points out some American words sounding “more glamorous” than their British equivalents are used more often currently. For example, she comments on the use of *apartment* instead of *flat*: “Who wants to live in a flat, a word redolent of damp problems and unidentifiable carpet stains, a word that just sounds – well, flat – when they could make their home in an apartment instead?” (ibid.). Another interesting phenomenon she provides, is an increasing tendency to use the word *film* when referring to a *foreign-language film* with subtitles and the word *movie* to refer to other films, especially comedies (ibid.).

Concerning this topic, Engels even suggests (as cited in Anderson 2017) that “by 2120 American English will have absorbed the British version entirely”.

5.2.2 Grammar

Perhaps the most evident sign of Americanization in grammar is the use of past tense where the perfective would be used a few years ago in sentences with *just*, *already* or *yet* (Lindsey 2019: 12). Therefore, instead of *I have just eaten.*, it is very likely to hear *I just ate.* Lindsey (2016) presumes that this phenomenon has such an extended use among young people because of the social media they are surrounded by. He claims that “Young

Brits today have no idea that their social media announcements were written by Americans. It's just part of their life." (ibid.).

With British English being more open to follow changes in the American, Baker (2017: 237) describes American English being ahead of British English in terms of grammar. Perhaps not leading it but surely being ahead.

6 Summary of Theoretical part

At this point, before proceeding to Analytical part, let us summarize Theoretical part. Supposedly, the changes in SSB, described above, may be considered as a result of the influence of American English on British English, since, as already discussed, the power of American English is enormous. However, it can also be regarded as a result of a linguistic change, because every language develops through time (Trudgill & Hannah 2017: 12-13). Moreover, every language chooses the easiest way possible in its development, following the principle of least effort (Wells 1982: 94). Thus, it is only natural that it is the British pronunciation, which in general demands more effort while pronouncing some single phonemes that is becoming more similar to the American pronunciation, which may be regarded as more relaxed.

Be it either way, it is for sure that the recent development in SSB approximates it to GA in some ways. The examples of this recent development are, for instance, weak vowel merger, replacement of PALM by TRAP in BATH-words, yod-dropping, /t/-voicing, G-dropping or replacement of /əʊ/ in GOAT by /oʊ/. In addition, the phenomenon of smoothing is making SSB more similar to GA, because the centring diphthongs, which smoothing eliminates, lack in GA as well. On the other hand, SSB and GA retain their distinctive features such as non-rhoticity of SSB and rhoticity of GA or the difference in the LOT vowel. Besides, some developments in SSB have no parallels in GA, such as the increased use of glottal stop.

ANALYTICAL PART

In Analytical part of the thesis two recordings of two different SSB speakers are analysed. The aim of the analysis is to find the answer to the main research question stated in Introduction: Does the exposure to the American spoken language affect the pronunciation of British people? More precisely, are there any features of the American pronunciation in their accent? Moreover, Analytical part examines the progressiveness of the speakers within SSB in connection to their age, gender and the impact of the American English on their pronunciation.

The speakers were carefully chosen to conform to the description of an SSB speaker, having an accent which cannot be assigned to a specific area, without any regional features. Thereafter, they were both born in the south of England, well-educated and, furthermore, can be heard in public life, as they are both publicly known personalities. To provide certain variedness, the speakers are of a different gender as well as of a different age, hence, Speaker 1 is a woman in her thirties whereas Speaker 2 is a man in his late fifties.

The format of the recordings was aimed to be rather informal than formal to prevent observing speeches prepared in advance. For this reason, two interviews were chosen, as during an interview speakers focus rather on the sense or message of their speech than on the form and the pronunciation. This confirms the fact that very often informal English is used in the recordings as well as filler words. The recordings were transcribed and can be seen in Appendix 1 and Appendix 2. Regarding the transcription of the recordings, multiple replays and the possibility to slow down the video to 0.75; 0.5 and even 0.25 of the original speed were used to properly identify the realization of concrete phonemes.

Analytical part is divided into several chapters, a chapter is dedicated to each speaker. First, the information about speaker's background is given, including details about their age, family, job and education. In addition, assumptions concerning their pronunciation are posed. Afterwards, the tables with particular phenomena observed in the recordings are offered and, subsequently, the language material collected in the tables is analysed. The analysis starts first with vowels and then continues with consonants. In the analysis the speakers' realized pronunciation is always compared with the dictionary pronunciation. Finally, the speeches of both speakers are mutually compared, and the conclusion is drawn.

7 Speaker 1 – Emma Watson

7.1 Emma Watson's profile

Emma Watson is an English actress and activist. Although she was born in Paris in 1990, she stayed there only until the age of five and, subsequently, moved with her mother to Oxford, where she attended the Dragon School and afterwards the Headington School. Eventually, she graduated from Brown University in the USA with a bachelor's degree in English literature (Emma Watson, Wikipedia).

Her acting career started at the age of eleven. She is perhaps most recognized for her portrayal of a young witch Hermione Granger in the Harry Potter saga. The most recent roles would involve performances in the American films *Little Women*, *Beauty and the Beast* or *The Circle* (Emma Watson, ČSFD).

In 2014 she stepped out as a feminist, giving a speech for the UN within the campaign *HeForShe* fighting for gender equality. Nowadays, she keeps being engaged in such activities as she publicly speaks out against gender inequality and race discrimination (Emma Watson, Wikipedia).

Having been raised in Oxford, where she attended prestigious schools, and with both her parents being lawyers (Emma Watson, Wikipedia), Watson is expected to be an SSB speaker. Concerning her studies in the USA and her numerous performances in Hollywood films, the influence of the American English could be noticeable in her speech. As she is in her thirties, she can be considered a representative of the younger generation which is more likely to adopt changes and new tendencies in a language. Therefore, her speech might reflect current tendencies in SSB rather than old RP forms.

A part of her interview for *British Vogue* was transcribed from 5:00 till 5:45. The transcript can be seen in Appendix 1. In the following subchapters Watson's speech will be further analysed.

7.2 Vowels

Phoneme or phenomenon	Examples of words or phrases	Cambridge Dictionary pronunciation	Realised pronunciation	Commentary
/ɪə/	really clearly	/'rɪəli/ /'klɪəli/	/'rɪ:li/ /'rɪli/ /'klɪ:li/	smoothing /ɪə/ → /ɪ:/

	hear here	/hɪə/ /hɪə/	/hɪ:/ /hɪ:/	
/eə/	care of self-care compare	/'keərən/ /,self'keə/ /kəm'peə/	/'kɛ:rən/ /,self'kɛ:/ /kəm'pɛ:/	smoothing /eə/ → /ɛ:/
/ʊə/	actually	/'æktʃuəli/ /'æktʃuəli/ /'æktʃəli/ /'æktʃʊli/	/'æktʃəli/ /krʊ:l/ /krʊəl/	/ʊə/, /ʊ/ → /ə/
	cruel	/'kru:əl/ /krʊəl/		smoothing /ʊə/ → /ʊ:/
/aʊə/	our	/aʊə/ /ɑ:/	/ɑ:/	smoothing /aʊə/ → /ɑ:/
weak vowel merger	goodness	/'gʊdnəs/ /'gʊdnɪs/	/'gʊdnəs/ (/'gədnəs/)	/ʊ/ → /ə/
	meaningfully	/'mi:nɪŋfəli/ /'mi:nɪŋfʊli/	/'mi:nɪŋfəli/	
	education	/,edʒʊ'keɪʃən/ /,edʒʊ'keɪʃən/	/,edʒə'keɪʃən/	
	foreign	/'fɔrɪn/ /'fɔrən/	/'fɔrən/	/ɪ/ → /ə/
	reform (V)	/rɪ'fɔ:m/ /rə'fɔ:m/	/rə'fɔ:m/	
BATH /ɑ:/ X /æ/	X	X	X	not observed
/ɔ:/ → /ɒ/	X	X	X	not observed
GOAT /əʊ/ X /oʊ/	know	/nəʊ/	/nəʊ/	RP /əʊ/
	okay	/əʊ'keɪ/	/əʊ'keɪ/	
	go	/gəʊ/	/gəʊ/	
	social (media)	/'səʊʃəl/	/'soʊʃəl/	GA /oʊ/

Table 1 Vowels observed in the recording by Speaker 1

7.3. Analysis of vowels

7.3.1 Pronunciation of diphthongs and triphthongs

The first observed phenomenon called smoothing, which is in other words the use of long monophthongs instead of the centring diphthongs (Lindsey 2019: 47), is well established in Watson's speech. Regarding /ɪə/ and /eə/, these are in all cases replaced by long /ɪ:/ and /ɛ:/.

It should be mentioned that even if a word, traditionally used with a centring diphthong, is pronounced deliberately and rather slowly, the diphthong is not used. Furthermore, Watson applies smoothing even in the case of triphthongs, for instance, /aʊə/ in the word *our* is replaced by long /ɑ:/.

Smoothing of the centring diphthongs is not generally displayed in dictionaries as can be seen in Table 1. Nonetheless, for instance, the *Routledge Dictionary of Pronunciation for Current English* (Upton & Kretzschmar 2017) offers the pronunciation of *really* with the long monophthong as a possible variant and also the pronunciation of *care* and *compare* with long /ɛ:/ as the only variant possible.

In SSB, there is a tendency for /ʊə/ in some words to disappear in favour of /ɔ:/, for instance, in *sure* or *poor* (Cruttenden 2014: 156). In case of these two words the pronunciation with /ɔ:/ is used in majority of dictionaries as the first variant possible. In the recording, Watson uses two words which can include the CURE diphthong – *actually* and *cruel*. In Watson's speech /ʊə/ in *cruel* changes into long /ʊ:/.

Yet, generally, smoothing of /ʊə/ is not applied in this way. However, if we follow the rules of smoothing it makes a perfect sense. Since /ʊə/ is replaced by a longer version of its first part, therefore, a sound similar to the GOOSE vowel. The switch of the CURE vowel in this way is applied mainly in words, where /r/ follows, for example, in *during* (Lindsey 2019: 48).

Regarding the word *actually*, even though there is no variant of it which would include the CURE vowel in the *Cambridge English Pronouncing Dictionary* (Jones 2006), the *Routledge Dictionary of Pronunciation for Current English* (Upton & Kretzschmar 2017), for instance, mentions the pronunciation with the diphthong, thus /'ak(t)ʃʊəli/, on the first place. However, what is taking place in the development of the pronunciation of *actually* may not be regarded as smoothing. Supposedly, Watson's pronunciation as /'æktʃəli/ could be considered as a result of weak vowel merger. The pronunciation of *actually* might shift from /'æktʃəli/ into /'æktʃəli/. Therefore, /ʊ/ is replaced by the schwa which is a typical example of weak vowel merger.

In pronunciation of the GOAT vowel, Watson appears to be quite immune to the SSB tendency to pronounce it in the American way with /oʊ/ instead of the British /əʊ/. The American pronunciation with /oʊ/ was observed only in the word *social* in the phrase *social media*. As it was spotted in this particular collocation, it could be assumed that it is not a coincidence. The term social media may be very often used on British as well as on American TV and in various other medias. Being surrounded by American media and also by social media where this term may be heard with the American pronunciation, this could be the reason why this particular word was pronounced with /oʊ/. This phenomenon, referred to as ‘GOAT allophony’ (Lindsey 2019: 30), is in SSB very well established in words with a syllable-final dark /l/ (ibid.). However, it is not the case of the word *social*. To discover whether Watson’s pronunciation of *social* with /oʊ/ is common or even standard among British speakers let us consult the YouGlish site. From 10 recordings and, thus 10 speakers, who were listened to, most of them had GOAT backing, or in other words pronunciation with /oʊ/, in the word *social*. It is also very interesting that in 5 cases the word *social* was used in exactly the same collocation as in Watson’s speech – *social media*.

7.3.2 Pronunciation of /ʊ/ and /ɪ/ in weak syllables

Weak vowel merger, a phenomenon typical of the American English (Wells 1982: 167), is very well established in Watson’s speech, too. Generally speaking, she uses it wherever possible. Even there, where the dictionaries do not display it.

This phenomenon is in many cases reflected in the *Cambridge English Pronouncing Dictionary* (Jones 2006), which may suggest that it is applied by a number of SSB speakers. However, in some monolingual online dictionaries the traditional RP variants are still the only pronunciation possibilities offered. Yet, it is the online dictionaries that majority of speakers use when they are not sure with their pronunciation. Figure 8 offers the comparison of the pronunciation of the five words used by Watson as transcribed in four online monolingual dictionaries. The transcriptions given in bold signify a pronunciation different from other transcriptions in the row.

	Cambridge online	Oxford online	Longman online	Collins online	Watson’s pron.
goodness	/ˈɡʊdnəs/	/ˈɡʊdnəs/	/ˈɡʊdnəs/	/ˈɡʊdnəs/	/ˈɡʊdnəs/ (/ˈɡædnəs/)

meaningfully	/ˈmiːnɪŋfəli/	/ˈmiːnɪŋfəli/	/ˈmiːnɪŋfəli/	/ˈmiːnɪŋfʊli/	/ˈmiːnɪŋfəli/
education	/ˌedʒʊˈkeɪʃən/	/ˌedʒʊˈkeɪʃn/	/ˌedʒʊˈkeɪʃən/	/ˌedʒʊˈkeɪʃən/	/ˌedʒəˈkeɪʃən/
foreign	/ˈfɒrən/	/ˈfɒrən/	/ˈfɒrɪn/	/ˈfɒrɪn/	/ˈfɒrən/
reform (V)	/rɪˈfɔːm/	/rɪˈfɔːm/	/rɪˈfɔːm/	/rɪˈfɔːm/	/rəˈfɔːm/

Figure 8 Weak vowel merger in online dictionaries

Nevertheless, pronouncing dictionaries offer more variants, in the *Cambridge English Pronouncing Dictionary* (Jones 2006) they are sorted according to the frequency of use among speakers. In Figure 9, transcriptions of these words in two pronouncing dictionaries being the *Cambridge English Pronouncing Dictionary* (Jones 2006) and the *Routledge Dictionary of Pronunciation for Current English* (Upton & Kretzschmar 2017) are given and compared with Watson's pronunciation. The two symbols /ə/ and /ɪ/ used in the *Routledge Dictionary* are applied for the words where the pronunciation with /ɪ/ and /ʊ/ as well as with the schwa is permitted (Upton & Kretzschmar 2017: xi).

Word	Cambridge Dictionary pronunciation	Routledge Dictionary pronunciation	Realised pronunciation
goodness	/ˈgʊdnəs/ /ˈgʊdnɪs/	/ˈgʊdnəs/	/ˈgʊdnəs/ (/ˈgədnəs/)
meaningfully	/ˈmiːnɪŋfəli/ /ˈmiːnɪŋfʊli/	/ˈmiːnɪŋfəli/ /ˈmiːnɪŋfli/	/ˈmiːnɪŋfəli/
education	/ˌedʒʊˈkeɪʃən/ /ˌedʒʊˈkeɪʃən/	/ˌɛdjəˈkeɪʃn/ /ˌɛdʒəˈkeɪʃn/	/ˌedʒəˈkeɪʃən/
foreign	/ˈfɒrɪn/ /ˈfɒrən/	/ˈfɒrɪn/ /ˈfɒrn/	/ˈfɒrən/
reform (V)	/rɪˈfɔːm/ /rəˈfɔːm/	/rɛˈfɔːm/	/rəˈfɔːm/

Figure 9 Weak vowel merger in pronouncing dictionaries

Let us start the analysis with the word *goodness*. Watson sometimes pronounces it in accord with both the pronouncing dictionaries as /ˈgʊdnəs/ but also with a very weak /ʊ/ sounding more like the schwa. Therefore, the final realization sounds almost as /ˈgədnəs/. Yet,

from one point of view it could be considered weak vowel merger, as /ʊ/ before a consonant is replaced by the schwa. However, weak vowel merger only happens in weak syllables as the schwa cannot be stressed and, therefore, cannot normally appear in strong syllables. Nonetheless, even the schwa can be stressed in certain environments. A good example is the word *because* which, according to the *Cambridge English Pronouncing Dictionary* (Jones 2006), can be pronounced as /bə'kəz/ with the schwa being stressed. Thus, it may be possible to pronounce *goodness* with the stressed schwa as /'gədnəs/.

Watson pronounces the word *meaningfully* with the schwa as transcribed in both the pronouncing dictionaries. This pronunciation of *meaningfully* is perhaps quite common among SSB speakers, as it is put as the first pronunciation variant. The *Routledge Dictionary of Pronunciation for Current English* (Upton & Kretzschmar 2017) even gives the variant with neither /ʊ/ nor /ə/ but with a syllabic *l*. Regarding the American pronunciation, it is always given with the schwa.

As can be seen above, Watson's pronunciation of the word *education*, in terms of weak vowel merger, is a deviation from the *Cambridge English Pronouncing Dictionary* (Jones 2006). Although it conforms to the current tendencies in SSB, Watson's pronunciation is given only in the *Routledge Dictionary of Pronunciation for Current English* (Upton & Kretzschmar 2017). The variant with the schwa for the American pronunciation is displayed in both the pronouncing dictionaries. Once again, the YouGlish site will be used to find out which variant is more common among British speakers. Approximately, half of the speakers uses schwa instead of FOOT in the word *education*; surprisingly, one of them being even the Duchess of Cambridge in her speech on Early Intervention for Children & Families.

Concerning /ɪ/ being replaced by the schwa, it is perhaps more common with *foreign* than with *reform* based on their transcriptions in the online dictionaries. Watson's pronunciation of *foreign* with the schwa is not used only in the Longman and the Collins Dictionary. On the other hand, the situation with *reform* is different. Watson's pronunciation with the schwa is used only in the pronouncing dictionaries as a possible variant. Thus, the pronunciation of *foreign* with the schwa may be considered as more or less standard in comparison to *reform* where the pronunciation with the schwa is perhaps less standard or even rare. This may suggest that in this regard Watson is quite a progressive user of SSB.

7.3.3 Pronunciation of BATH words

Concerning the BATH words pronounced with /ɑ:/ in RP and SSB and with /æ/ in GA with a tendency to be pronounced with /æ/ even in SSB (Lindsey 2019: 42), no such words

were captured in Watson’s speech. The issue is that this phenomenon involves a small group of words, which were not used in this particular recording.

7.3.4 Pronunciation of words with the THOUGHT vowel /ɔ:/

Unfortunately, no words containing /ɔ:/ which could possibly be replaced by /ɒ/ (Lindsey 2019: 30) were used by Watson. Hence, this phenomenon cannot be commented on.

7.4 Consonants

Phoneme or phenomenon	Examples of words or phrases	Cambridge Dictionary pronunciation	Realised pronunciation	Commentary
yod-dropping	pursuing	/pə'sju:ɪŋ/ /pɜ:-/ /-su:ɪŋ/	/pə'sju:ɪŋ/	no yod-dropping
yod-coalescence	what you	/wɒt ju/	/wɒt ju/	no yod-coalescence
	at your	/æt jɔ:/	/æʔ jɔ:/	glottal stop
	education	/,edʒʊ'keɪʃən/ /,edjʊ'keɪʃən/ actually /'æktʃuəli/ /'æktjuəli/ /'æktʃəli/ /'æktʃʊli/	/,edʒə'keɪʃən/ /'æktʃəli/	yod-coalescence
T-realization	coming out as	/'kʌmɪŋ aʊt əz/	/'kʌmɪŋ aʊʔ əz/	glottal stop word- finally
	what I	/wɒt aɪ/	/wɒʔ aɪ/	
	hit (hit hard)	/hɪt/	/hɪʔ/	
ing /ɪŋ/	it was	/ɪt wəz/	/ɪʔ wəz/	/t/
	not okay	/nɒt ,əʊ'keɪ/	/nɒʔ ,əʊ'keɪ/	
	just so	/dʒʌst səʊ/	/dʒʌst səʊ/	
	imposter	/ɪm'pɒstə/	/ɪm'pɒstə/	no G-dropping
	actively	/'æktɪvli/	/'æktɪvli/	
	doing	/'du:ɪŋ/	/'du:ɪŋ/	
	looking	/'lʊkɪŋ/	/'lʊkɪŋ/	

Table 2 Consonants observed in the recording by Speaker 1

7.5 Analysis of consonants

7.5.1 Yod-dropping

The analysis of the consonants in Watson's speech starts with a phenomenon known as yod-dropping. Yod-dropping refers to the pronunciation without the yod or in other words /j/. As mentioned in Theoretical part, there is a tendency in SSB to pronounce these words without the yod as in GA (Collins & Mess 2013: 96). However, the word *pursue* is together with *assume* an exception, as the /j/ tends to be preserved in these words by SSB speakers (Lindsey 2019: 60). Accordingly, Watson pronounces it as /pə'sju:/ in contrast to the American form /pə'su:/ in which the yod is dropped. Nevertheless, the *Cambridge English Pronouncing Dictionary* (Jones 2006) offers also a more progressive variant without the yod even for the British pronunciation.

7.5.2 Yod-coalescence

Another interesting phenomenon observed is known as yod-coalescence. Watson applies it word-internally in the word *education* where the consonant cluster /dj/ is replaced by the affricate consonant /dʒ/. Based on the variants given in the pronouncing dictionaries, the pronunciation with /dʒ/ seems to prevail as it is given in both dictionaries.

Concerning the word *actually*, Watson realizes its pronunciation with the affricate consonant /tʃ/. However, it is also possible to use the post-alveolar fricative /ʃ/. This pronunciation variant is not offered in the *Cambridge English Pronouncing Dictionary* (Jones 2006); nevertheless, the *Routledge Dictionary of Pronunciation for Current English* (Upton & Kretzschmar 2017) does offer such option.

On the other hand, yod coalescence across word boundaries does not occur in Watson's speech. In such environments, she prefers to use the glottal stop or pronounces both words as if they stood separately.

7.5.3 T-realization

As mentioned above, regarding the realization of *t*, Watson prefers to use the glottal stop in many cases. Especially, the word-final use of the glottal stop is very common in her speech either before a consonant or before a vowel, for instance, in *at̚ your*, *coming out̚*, *what̚ I*, *hit̚ hard*, *not̚ okay*. Nowadays, the use of the glottal stop before a consonant is considered to be a standard feature of SSB (Lindsey 2019: 67-68). However, its use before a vowel is regarded as less standard (ibid.). This fact may suggest that Watson is a more advanced user of SSB.

On the contrary, no word-initial or word-internal use of the glottal stop was observed. In the latter environments, Watson usually chooses to realize *t* as unvoiced, alveolar plosive /t/.

The current tendency to pronounce /t/ in a more American way as a voiced consonant mostly unrecognizable of /d/ (Lindsey 2019: 69; Collins & Mees 2013: 205) was not observed in Watson's speech.

To sum up, Watson's preference in T-realization is to pronounce the sound either as unvoiced, alveolar plosive consonant or as the glottal stop.

7.5.4 G-dropping

The last phenomenon observed was the pronunciation of the *-ing* ending. In all cases, Watson pronounces it in a standard way as /ɪŋ/. In the five-minute recording not a single case of G-dropping was noticed.

7.6 Summary of the findings

Given the above, it can be concluded that Emma Watson is quite a progressive SSB speaker as many of the current tendencies in SSB such as smoothing, weak vowel merger or word-final use of the glottal stop are very well established in her spoken production.

Regarding the American influence on her pronunciation, it is reflected mainly in weak vowel merger, which is typically American. As to the phenomenon of /t/-voicing, G-dropping or pronunciation of the BATH-words with TRAP, these were not spotted in the recording. However, for example, the realization of the GOAT vowel in the American way was observed in one case.

8 Speaker 2 – Boris Johnson

8.1 Boris Johnson's profile

Boris Johnson is a British politician, leader of the Conservative Party, currently serving as the Prime Minister of the United Kingdom. He was born in 1964 in New York City, where his father studied at Columbia University. As his parents changed their domicile quite often in his early childhood, he lived in several cities in the USA, in Oxford, in a village near Winsford in the south of England or in Brussels. Finally, after divorcing his father, his mother settled in London. However, at that time, Johnson already studied at Eton College, the boarding school near Windsor. Later, he attended Balliol College of the University of Oxford. He is well known for his Eurosceptic opinions, under his leadership the UK, finally, withdrew from the European Union in 2019 (Boris Johnson, Wikipedia).

To sum up, Boris Johnson comes from a very well educated and situated family. His mother is an artist, born in Oxford to a family of intellectuals. His father was educated at Sherborne School, a boarding school for boys, and then at Exeter College of the University of Oxford (Boris Johnson, Wikipedia). Furthermore, Johnson himself was educated at the most prestigious British schools. Hence, he is expected to be an SSB speaker. The American influence might be noticeable in his speech as he spent some time in the USA as a child. However, the influence of his childhood experience with American English is rather improbable. Due to his age and, also high and important social status, he is expected to be rather a conservative speaker, with his accent not displaying as much of the current tendencies.

A part of an interview with Johnson for the ITV show *This Morning* was observed and, consequently, transcribed from 0:00 till 8:14. The transcript can be found in Appendix 2. In the following subchapters, Johnson's speech will be analysed.

8.2 Vowels

Phoneme or phenomenon	Examples of words or phrases	Cambridge Dictionary pronunciation	Realised pronunciation	Commentary
/ɪə/	clear (V)	/klɪə/	/klɪə/	RP /ɪə/
	real	/rɪəl/	/rɪ:l/	smoothing /ɪə/ → /ɪ:/
	really	/'rɪəli/	/'rɪli/	/ɪə/ → /ɪ/

	clearly	/ˈkliːli/	/ˈkliːli/	smoothing /ɪə/ → /iː/
/eə/	where	/ˈhweə/	/ˈweː/	smoothing /eə/ → /ɛː/
/ʊə/	sure	/ʃɔː/ /ʃʊə/	/ʃʊɜː/ /ʃʊː/ /ʃɔː/	RP /ʊə/ + hesitation sound
				/ʊə/ → /ʊː/
				/ʊə/ → /ɔː/
/aʊə/	hours	/aʊəz/	/aʊəz/	RP /aʊə/
	our (hands)	/aʊə/ /ɑː/	/ɑːr/	smoothing /aʊə/ → /ɑː/
weak vowel merger	immediately	/ɪˈmiːdiətli/ /ɪˈmiːdiətli/	/ɪˈmiːdʒətli/ /ɪˈmiːdiətli/	/ɪ/ → /ə/
	individuals	/,ɪndɪˈvɪdʒuəlz/ /,ɪndəˈvɪdʒuəlz/ /,ɪndɪˈvɪdʒuəlz/ /,ɪndəˈvɪdʒuəlz/	/,ɪndɪˈvɪdʒuəlz/	RP /ɪ/
	illness	/ˈɪlnəs/ /ˈɪlnɪs/	/ˈɪlnɪs/	
	delay (V)	/dɪˈleɪ/ /dəˈleɪ/	/dəˈleɪ/	
	population	/,pɒpjəˈleɪʃən/ /,pɒpjʊˈleɪʃən/	/,pɒpjəˈleɪʃən/	/ʊ/ → /ə/
	restored	/rɪˈstɔːd/ /rəˈstɔːd/	/rɪˈstɔːd/	RP /ɪ/
BATH /ɑː/ X /æ/	fast	/fɑːst/	/fɑːst/	RP /ɑː/
/ɔː/ → /ʊ/	X	X	X	not observed
GOAT /əʊ/ X /oʊ/	diagnosis	/,daɪəgˈnəʊsɪs/	/,daɪəgˈnəʊsɪs/	RP /əʊ/
	location	/ləʊˈkeɪʃən/	/ləʊˈkeɪʃən/	
	showing	/ˈʃəʊɪŋ/	/ˈʃəʊɪŋ/	
	whole	/ˈhəʊl/	/ˈhoʊl/	GA /oʊ/

Table 3 Vowels observed in the recording by Speaker 2

8.3 Analysis of vowels

8.3.1 Pronunciation of diphthongs and triphthongs

Let us start the analysis of Johnson's vowels with the diphthong /ɪə/. While pronouncing it, Johnson mostly applies smoothing. Therefore, *real* or *clearly* are pronounced with a long monophthong /ɪ:/. However, for instance, in the case of *really* the short /ɪ/ is used instead of the diphthong. Furthermore, in pronunciation of *clear* Johnson retains the variant with the diphthong, which is the only variant possible in the *Cambridge English Pronouncing Dictionary* (Jones 2006).

Concerning the diphthong /eə/, it was observed only in the word *where*, in which its smoothed variant with /ɛ:/ is used by Johnson. Although in the *Cambridge English Pronouncing Dictionary* (Jones 2006) the symbol /eə/ is used for the SQUARE vowel, suggesting that the pronunciation with the diphthong is the only possible, in the *Routledge Dictionary of Pronunciation for Current English* (Upton & Kretzschmar 2017) the diphthong is no longer used and is replaced by the long monophthong /ɛ:/. This change of SQUARE might be very common among SSB speakers. Even the British queen uses long monophthong in the word *care*, for instance, in her Coronavirus Broadcast, which is quite interesting as she can be considered as a rather conservative speaker from an older generation.

The SQUARE diphthong is, for the time being, the only centring diphthong omitted in this current dictionary. However, it is possible to expect that in the future all the centring diphthongs might disappear as they might be replaced by long monophthongs.

The last centring diphthong observed was the CURE vowel /ʊə/, which was in Johnson's speech used only in the word *sure*. The pronunciation of this particular word is very interesting. Traditionally, in RP, it contained the CURE vowel. However, the word *sure* as well as *poor* has undergone the process of smoothing and nowadays, would be pronounced by most speakers with the long /ʊ:/. This confirms the fact that the variant with the long monophthong is used on the first place in the *Cambridge English Pronouncing Dictionary* (Jones 2006). Nevertheless, Johnson's pronunciation of *sure* is not limited on the one variant only. Although the variant with the long /ʊ:/ can be heard, it is not by far the only variant possible.

The first non-standard pronunciation would be /ʃʊɜ:/. Presumably, the issue is that Johnson's intention was to pronounce it as /ʃʊə/; however, he fluently continued into the hesitation sound represented by /ɜ:/. Another variant, which may be regarded as non-standard,

as it is not reflected in any of the two pronouncing dictionaries used, was /ʃʊ:/. This variant is in accord with the rules of smoothing; however, normally, /ʊə/ in *sure* changes in favour of /ɔ:/. Cruttenden (2014: 85) suggests that the pronunciation with /ʊ:/ is an older variant of smoothing and is a forerunning pronunciation of the one with /ɔ:/. Conversely, perhaps, this may be considered as a result of the influence of the American pronunciation, since in GA the word *sure* would be pronounced as /ʃʊr/. If we consult the YouGlish site, most British speakers across generations use the variant with the long /ɔ:/. Hence, even though Johnson can be considered an older speaker, it is improbable that his realization of the word *sure* would be the result of the old way of smoothing of this word. It might be more probable that it is the result of the American influence.

As for the triphthong /aʊə/, in the word *our* Johnson applies smoothing, which is even reflected in the *Cambridge English Pronouncing Dictionary* (Jones 2006); however, in the word *hours* he does not. In addition, Johnson's realised pronunciation of *our hands* is /ɑ:r hændz/, hence, the linking /r/ in *our* is realised even though there is no following vowel, which is a typical feature of the American pronunciation. This phenomenon appears in Johnson's speech in two cases and will be discussed later.

Concerning the GOAT diphthong, it is in most cases pronounced with the schwa by Johnson. Nonetheless, the word *whole* is pronounced in the American way with /o/. This pronunciation conforms to the current tendencies in SSB, where in some words the GOAT vowel is pronounced as /oo/. Lindsey (2019: 30) describes that this phenomenon is common in words with a syllable-final dark /l/, therefore, in words such as *control*, *goal*, *hold*, *old*, *told* or *whole*.

8.3.2 Pronunciation of /ʊ/ and /ɪ/ in weak syllables

The phenomenon known as weak vowel merger refers to the pronunciation of schwa instead of /ʊ/ or /ɪ/ in weak syllables. In Johnson's speech, this phenomenon can be observed approximately in half of the words, where it could be applied. Johnson prefers the pronunciation with schwa in *immediately*, *delay* or *population*, whereas he does not in *individuals*, *illness* or *restored*. However, in the word *immediately*, not only is it possible to apply weak vowel merger in the penultimate syllable, as Johnson does, but also in the first syllable as reflected in the *Routledge Dictionary of Pronunciation for Current English* (Upton & Kretzschmar 2017).

With *immediately*, *individuals*, *population* and *restored* Johnson chooses the first pronunciation variant given in the *Cambridge English Pronouncing Dictionary* (Jones 2006).

Since the pronunciation variants are given in the order of frequency of use, it can be assumed that with these words he uses the most common variants among SSB speakers.

It is Johnson's pronunciation of *illness* and *delay* that is quite interesting. While in *illness*, Johnson uses the less common pronunciation possibility with /ɪ/, in *delay* he goes for the less common variant with schwa. This fact leads us to the inconsistency of the use of weak vowel merger in Johnson's speech. Whereas in the pronunciation of *illness* he remains rather conservative, in the pronunciation of *delay* he seems to be a more progressive speaker.

To summarize, Johnson's use of weak vowel merger is not very consistent. His pronunciation is in most cases in accord with the first pronunciation possibility offered in the *Cambridge English Pronouncing Dictionary* (Jones 2006). In some words, he prefers to use the modern variant with schwa, while in other words he retains the old variant with /ɪ/ or /ʊ/.

8.3.3 Pronunciation of BATH words

Only one word containing the PALM vowel in SSB and the TRAP vowel in GA was observed. The word *fast*, which was by Johnson pronounced with long /ɑ:/. Although it is suggested that some SSB speakers would use TRAP instead of PALM in these so called BATH words, it is not displayed in any pronouncing dictionary.

8.3.4 Pronunciation of the words with the THOUGHT vowel /ɔ:/

Unfortunately, no words containing the THOUGHT vowel which could be possibly replaced by LOT were observed in the recording.

8.3.5 Pronunciation of the KIT vowel

Johnson's pronunciation of the KIT vowel /ɪ/ is included into the analysis since it is quite unusual. Normally, in SSB, KIT is a short, close, central vowel pronounced with slightly spread lips and lax tongue (Roach 1991: 14; Cruttenden 2014: 113). However, Johnson's KIT is very tense and close, even similar to the French [i] used, for example, in the word *Paris*. In the recording it can be heard, for instance, in the word *big* where it is very well noticeable. Perhaps, the matter is that it is the regional pronunciation of KIT. As Cruttenden (2014: 115) puts it: "Regionally the use of a very close /ɪ/(=[i̯]), occurring in all positions, should be noted as particularly characteristic of Birmingham speech." After this finding, Johnson's life was re-examined once again; however, no connection between Johnson's life and Birmingham was found. Since the issue is that it is the regional pronunciation, it is beyond the scope of this thesis

which is not focused on regional accents. Nevertheless, it is well-marked element in the speech of an SSB speaker, therefore, it should be at least mentioned.

8.4 Consonants

Phoneme or phenomenon	Examples of words or phrases	Cambridge Dictionary pronunciation	Realised pronunciation	Commentary
yod-dropping	X	X	X	not observed
yod-coalescence	immediately	/ɪ'mi:diətli/ /ɪ'mi:diɪtli/ /ɪ'mi:dʒətli/	/ɪ'mi:dʒətli/ /ɪ'mi:diətli/	yod-coalescence
	individuals	/,ɪndɪ'vɪdʒuəlz/ /,ɪndə'vɪdʒuəlz/ /,ɪndɪ'vɪdjuəlz/ /,ɪndə'vɪdjuəlz/	/,ɪndɪ'vɪdʒuəlz/	
	intuitively that you	/ɪn'tju:ɪtɪvli/ /ðæt jə/	/ɪn'tʃu:ɪtɪvli/ /ðæt jə/	no yod-coalescence
T-realization	not at all	/nɒt ət ɔ:l/	/nɒt ət ɔ:l/	RP /t/
	get it	/get ɪt/	/get ɪt/	
	better	/'betə/	/'betə/	
	meeting (V)	/'mi:tɪŋ/	/'mi:tɪŋ/	RP /t/ or GA /t̚/
	putting	/'pʊtɪŋ/	/'pʊtɪn/ /'pʊt̚ɪn/	
	let (me)	/let/	/leʔ/	glottal stop word- finally
	about (the, what)	/ə'baʊt/	/ə'baʊʔ/	
	what (the, we, they)	/wɒt/	/wɒʔ/	
	at (the moment)	/æt/ /ət/	/æʔ/	
	hot (water)	/hɒt/	/hɒʔ/	
	not (exponentially)	/nɒt/	/nɒʔ/	
	get (through)	/get/	/geʔ/	
	British	/'brɪtɪʃ/	/'brɪt̚ɪʃ/	GA /t̚/
	water	/'wɔ:tə/	/'wɔ:tə/ /'wɔ:t̚ə/	

	pretty (much)	/'prɪti/	/'prɪʈi/	
ing /ɪŋ/	identifying	/aɪ'dentɪfaɪŋ/	/aɪ'dentɪfaɪŋ/	no G-dropping
	confirming	/kən'fɜ:mɪŋ/	/kən'fɜ:mɪŋ/	
	building	/'bɪldɪŋ/	/'bɪldɪŋ/	
	putting	/'pʊtɪŋ/	/'pʊtɪn/ /'pʊʈɪn/	G-dropping

Table 4 Consonants observed in the recording by Speaker 2

8.5 Analysis of consonants

8.5.1 Yod-dropping

Unfortunately, the very first phenomenon, referred to as yod-dropping, cannot be commented on, as no words concerning it were observed in the recording.

8.5.2 Yod-coalescence

Compared to yod-dropping, yod-coalescence offers more opportunities for analysis. Generally speaking, Johnson applies yod-coalescence word-internally in words such as *immediately*, *individuals* or *intuitively*.

Regarding the word *individual*, the pronunciation with /dʒ/ is the most common variant based on the *Cambridge English Pronouncing Dictionary* (Jones 2006). However, the dictionary does not include variant with /tʃ/ for *intuitively*, as Johnson uses it. Concerning the word *intuitively*, the *Routledge Dictionary of Pronunciation for Current English* (Upton & Kretzschmar 2017), which seems to be more progressive in this regard, provides us with the traditional variant with /tj/ as well as with the variant with /tʃ/, therefore, /ɪn'tʃu:ɪvli/.

Nevertheless, it is only the *Cambridge English Pronouncing Dictionary* (Jones 2006) which gives a variant with /dʒ/ for the word *immediately*. Yet, it seems quite logical that the *Routledge Dictionary of Pronunciation for Current English* (Upton & Kretzschmar 2017) does not offer it, as the word *immediately* does not even involve the consonant cluster /dj/. To understand Johnson's pronunciation, let us consult the *Routledge Dictionary of Pronunciation for Current English* (Upton & Kretzschmar 2017) where *immediately* is transcribed with the diphthong /ɪə/ and the online *CUBE Dictionary* (Lindsey & Szigetvári) where *immediately* is transcribed as /ɪmɪjdɪjətɪlj/. As already mentioned in Theoretical part, the *CUBE Dictionary* (Lindsey & Szigetvári) is an online pronouncing dictionary for current British English made by Geoff Lindsey. Lindsey uses his own symbols for transcription, which can be seen in Figure 2

in Theoretical part (see Chapter 2). To see the pronunciation of *immediately* from the three pronouncing dictionaries at one place, Figure 10 was made.

Cambridge Dictionary	Routledge Dictionary	CUBE Dictionary	Johnson's pronunciation
/ɪ'mi:diətli/	/ɛ'mi:diətli/	/ɪmɪjdɪjətli/	/ɪ'mi:dʒətli/
/ɪ'mi:diɪtli/			/ɪ'mi:diətli/
/ɪ'mi:dʒətli/			

Figure 10 Pronunciation of the word *immediately*

In the *Routledge Dictionary of Pronunciation for Current English* (Upton & Kretzschmar 2017) the NEAR diphthong is used. Probably, the NEAR diphthong /ɪə/, first, might have undergone the process of smoothing, therefore, /ɪə/ might have been replaced by long /ɪ:/ or even /i:/ which is transcribed as /ɪj/ in the CUBE dictionary. Hence, the /j/ sound, which is necessary for the yod-coalescence, is present. However, there is /ɪ/ between /d/ and /j/. Presumably, it might be pronounced even without /ɪ/ which could be dropped. Therefore, the consonant cluster /dj/ could be replaced by the affricate consonant /dʒ/.

The Lindsey's transcription in the CUBE dictionary, which can be perceived as “provoking” (Wells 2012), can help explain phenomena which are not displayed in other dictionaries. If we examine the word *immediately* on the YouGlish site, we will find out that 7 out of 15 speakers use the variant with /dj/ while 8 speakers choose the variant with the affricate consonant. Thus, it is surprising that the variant with /dʒ/ cannot be found in the *Routledge Dictionary of Pronunciation for Current English* (Upton & Kretzschmar 2017) which is a more recent dictionary. However, we may suppose that in the near future this variant will be displayed in all dictionaries.

Nevertheless, no case of yod-coalescence across word boundaries was observed. Word-finally, Johnson prefers to use the glottal stop.

8.5.3 T-realization

As mentioned above, word-finally Johnson prefers to use the glottal stop. He uses it mainly before consonants, for instance, in *about*_ɾ *the*, *what*_ɾ *we*, *hot*_ɾ *water*, which is more common among SSB speakers than its use before vowels. Only one use of the glottal stop before a vowel was captured in *not*_ɾ *exponentially*.

Surprisingly, several uses of rather American pronunciation of /t/ were observed. Particularly, in *putting*, *British*, *water* and *pretty* Johnson uses /t/-voicing. The phenomenon of /t/-voicing occurs in SSB in a few particular words or word phrases such as *British*, *pretty much*, *what else*, *put it away*, *a lot of*. Therefore, Johnson's pronunciation conforms to the current tendencies. However, /t/-voicing is a feature typical of the American English.

In terms of aspiration of /t/, it is in some words very weak in Johnson's speech. When listening to the recording, the 0.25 speed was needed in some cases, to hear clearly, how exactly Johnson is realizing his *t*. Weak aspiration may be considered to be a feature of a more conservative or an old-fashioned speaker (Lindsey 2019: 55).

8.5.4 Rhoticity

It is very surprising that in two words, /r/ was pronounced at the end of a word, even though there was no vowel following, thus, it was not the case of the linking-/r/. This first case can be seen in Table 3 in the phrase *our hands*. The second being the word *water* which can be found in Table 4.

The pronunciation of *our hands* with /r/ would, perhaps, lead us to the phenomenon of 'H-dropping' which is "the loss of /h/ from stressed syllables" (Lindsey 2019: 74). According to Lindsey (2019: 74) it "sometimes occurs in the more informal speech of speakers who usually retain /h/". Nonetheless, Johnson clearly pronounced /h/ in the word *hands*.

Johnson is obviously an SSB speaker; however, his pronunciation of these two words hints towards a rhotic accent, for instance, GA as /r/ was realized as a post-alveolar approximant.

8.5.5 G-dropping

The last phenomenon G-dropping was observed in Johnson's speech in the word *putting*, where the non-standard pronunciation of *-ing* as /ɪn/ instead of the standard /ɪŋ/ was employed. Even though G-dropping is rather an American phenomenon, common in vernacular or informal speech and is "widely considered incorrect" (Lindsey 2019: 73), nowadays, it is – according to Lindsey (ibid.) – less stigmatized and can be heard even in TV news or in public life. However, just a few years ago, people using G-dropping might have been perceived as "ignorant and uneducated" (Wells 2016: 160). Johnson is clearly not uneducated, thus, the fact that he uses G-dropping may confirm Lindsey's statement that public attitude towards G-dropping is really changing.

8.6 Summary of the findings

Based on the analysis, Boris Johnson can be considered as a progressive SSB speaker. In some environments he uses smoothing; however, not always, as in some cases he remains quite conservative. The same applies to weak vowel merger, which can be observed in some words but not in others. Also, under the American influence, in some cases he uses the GOAT vowel in the American way. The word-internal use of yod-coalescence is very usual for him; nevertheless, its use across word boundaries was not spotted even once, as in such environments he prefers to use the glottal stop. Moreover, several uses of a voiced /t/ were observed as well as G-dropping. In addition, a curiosity in the distribution of /r/ was observed as well as his peculiar use of the KIT vowel.

9 Comparison of the speakers

Having used the findings from the previous two chapters, Table 5 was made to compare the appearance of the phenomena discussed in Theoretical part in the pronunciation of the two speakers. The tick symbol ✓ marks that the given phenomena appeared in the spoken production of the speaker at least in one case. Conversely, the cross symbol ✗ marks that the chosen phenomenon was not observed in the speaker's pronunciation even once.

	Speaker 1	Speaker 2
smoothing	✓	✓
weak vowel merger	✓	✓
PALM replaced by TRAP	not observed	✗
THOUGHT replaced by LOT	not observed	not observed
GA GOAT	✓	✓
yod-dropping	✗	not observed
yod-coalescence word-internally	✓	✓
yod-coalescence across word boundaries	✗	✗
glottal stop word-finally before V	✓	✓
glottal stop word-finally before C	✓	✓
glottal stop word-internally before V	✗	✗
glottal stop word-internally before C	✗	✗
GA /t/	✗	✓
G-dropping	✗	✓

Table 5 Comparison of the speakers

In the following subchapters, first, the comparison of the phenomena concerning vowels will be discussed and, subsequently, the phenomena concerning consonants.

9.1 Comparison of pronunciation of vowels

The pronunciation of diphthongs and triphthongs will be the first one to be commented on. Both Watson and Johnson apply smoothing to some extent. As for Watson, her use of the smoothed forms of the centring diphthongs seems to be more frequent, since in the recording she used long monophthongs in all words in which traditionally centring diphthongs were included. On the other hand, in Johnson's pronunciation the centring diphthongs can still be heard in certain environments, for instance in *clear* or *sure*.

The triphthong /aʊə/ in the word *our* was replaced by the smoothed form by both speakers. However, in the word *hour*, Johnson uses the triphthong. Unfortunately, it can be only estimated, if in this particular word Watson would use the triphthong or not.

In this regard, Watson seems to be more progressive, as she constantly replaces the centring diphthongs by long monophthongs.

Another issue regarding the pronunciation of diphthongs is realization of the GOAT diphthong. In the majority of cases, both speakers retain the typical British variant with the schwa. Nevertheless, even rather American pronunciation of GOAT was observed. Johnson's pronunciation of *whole* with American /oo/ conforms to the current tendencies in SSB, since it contains a syllable-final dark /l/. On the contrary, Watson's pronunciation of *social* with /oo/ may be a result of the American influence, as it is not a general tendency in SSB.

As for the replacement of PALM by TRAP and of THOUGHT by LOT, these two phenomena cannot be commented on, since the recordings did not contain such words. The only example would be the word *fast* used by Johnson; however, as the only example is available, it does not represent enough language material for the analysis.

Weak vowel merger appears in the pronunciation of both speakers. Watson seems to be a more progressive user of weak vowel merger since she uses schwa instead of KIT and FOOT in all words where possible. On the other hand, Johnson applies weak vowel merger in 3 out of 6 words.

To sum up, as regards the pronunciation of vowels by the two speakers, Watson seems to be more progressive in applying the current tendencies concerning pronunciation of vowels in her own accent. Similarly, her speech displays more noticeable features of the American pronunciation than Johnson's, especially in terms of the pronunciation of the GOAT diphthong and use of weak vowel merger. Such finding makes a perfect sense, as she is the younger of the two speakers, and therefore, may be more willing to adopt current tendencies in the language

to her own accent. Furthermore, being in her thirties, she is expected to be an active user of various social media where she may be exposed to the influence of the American English.

9.2 Comparison of pronunciation of consonants

Surprisingly, the language material concerning the pronunciation of consonants offers more opportunities for the mutual comparison. Nevertheless, it is not the case of yod-dropping, the very first phenomenon observed, as in the recordings only one word was observed in which yod-dropping could take place, however, it did not.

On the other hand, yod-coalescence offers more material for the comparison. Its word-internal use was observed in the production of both speakers. Generally speaking, both speakers apply it word-internally wherever they can, which shows quite a progressiveness in this aspect. However, in one instance, Johnson chooses the traditional variant with the consonant cluster /dj/. Namely, it is in the word *immediately*, the pronunciation of which Johnson realizes with /dj/ as well as /dʒ/.

Although yod-coalescence word-internally was very common in both recordings, surprisingly, its use across word boundaries was not spotted even once. In fact, word-finally both speakers make a high use of the glottal stop. Either before vowels or before consonants, the glottal stop represents a favourite realization of *t* for both speakers. However, in Watson's production its use is perhaps more extensive in comparison to Johnson, who in general does not use it before vowels. This fact hints towards Watson being a more progressive speaker in terms of the use of the glottal stop, as its use before vowels is considered less standard in comparison to its use before consonants.

Yet, the use of glottal stop word-internally was not noted in a single word by either speaker. Word-internally, Watson realizes her *t* as an unvoiced, alveolar plosive /t/. Compared to Watson, Johnson's pronunciation of *t* evinces the influence of the American English, since in certain words Johnson realizes *t* as a rather voiced consonant typical of GA. This phenomenon can be observed in four words – *water*, *British*, *pretty* and *putting*.

Moreover, not only does Johnson use GA /t/ but also one case of G-dropping was observed in his speech in the word *putting*. In these two regards, Johnson seems to be much more influenced by the American pronunciation than Watson, even though he is the older of the two speakers. A possible explanation could be that as the Prime Minister of the UK he meets many people who speak English, however, English is not their mother tongue. Therefore, their accent may be very often difficult to classify, perhaps being rather similar to American accent than British.

Conclusion

Taking into consideration all the information discussed in Theoretical part as well as all the findings presented in Analytical part, let us return to the research question stated in Introduction: Does the exposure to the American spoken language affect the pronunciation of British people? More precisely, are there any features of the American pronunciation in their accent?

It follows from Theoretical part that in the modern British pronunciation SSB, there are some features which were not typical of RP and which are moving it closer to the American pronunciation. However, it would be really difficult, and in our conditions even impossible, to establish whether these current tendencies are the result of the American influence or of a linguistic change. Yet, this phenomenon is very interesting and invites for further analysis. Nonetheless, this is beyond the scope of the present thesis, perhaps belonging rather to the field of sociolinguistics.

Following the information described in Theoretical part, the research carried in Analytical part provides the answer to the research question. The examined pronunciation of the two SSB speakers showed features typical of the American pronunciation such as weak vowel merger, GA pronunciation of the GOAT diphthong, GA pronunciation of /t/ or G-dropping. In the case of Speaker 2, pronunciation of /r/ at the end of two words when no vowel was following was even observed. However, with the exception of weak vowel merger, these tendencies do not appear in the pronunciation of either speaker regularly. Their use is often connected to the pronunciation of particular words. Nevertheless, it may be expected that these phenomena will gradually appear in the British pronunciation in larger extent in the following years. Therefore, in future the British pronunciation might be more similar to the American than it is today.

Although the number of two respondents may seem as sufficient within the scope of the Bachelor's thesis, the results of the research should not be generalised, because the corpus of the research includes rather a small number of speakers. The shortage of the language material as well as of speakers may be the biggest disadvantage of the research. However, the analysis was quite time-consuming and, in addition, space demanding.

Nevertheless, it could be interesting to extend the research within the Master's thesis and even move the research into, for example, the field of didactics of the English language. As this thesis examines the modern form of the pronunciation or accent widely taught to EFL students, for instance, study on the preferable accent among EFL teachers may bring some

interesting findings concerning whether the teachers prefer American or British accent and if British – do they prefer its traditional form RP or rather modern SSB with some American characteristics? Certainly, a possible variant would be extending the research and, for instance, cover more speakers from different branches such as reporters.

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Appendix 1

Appendix 1 involves a transcript of an interview with Speaker 1, Emma Watson for British Vogue. The transcript starts at 0:00 and continues until 5:45. Three question marks in a row symbolize an unidentifiable word.

reporter speaking

Hi, Paris.

reporter speaking

Thanks for doing this with me.

reporter speaking

We have.

reporter speaking

Haha, I really didn't know what you were gonna say that. I was really I felt nervous for a second but now I am very nervous.

reporter speaking

That is actually crazy, I was looking at your Instagram just yesterday.

reporter speaking

And I was like Paris is really good at taking selfies.

reporter speaking

Yes.

reporter speaking

Oh my goodness she's the dream. I did this speech for the UN this campaign that we launched called HeForShe and I had like a massive case of the imposter syndrome because suddenly I was like me coming coming out as this feminist was kind of concern and I was like okay wow to what do I anyway the imposter syndrome hit hit hard and I was kind I need to go to some people who've been doing this for a while and talk to them and

reporter speaking

Oh yeah, I was like okay I think ???

reporter speaking

And it was just a really helpful conversation because she was just so loving and accepting in terms of kind of everyone is where they are on their learning journey as long you're doing the work and you are actively seeking and pursuing understanding and connection genuinely from a curious place then you're gonna be fine.

reporter speaking

I did, yeah.

reporter speaking

Social media is a really interesting space and I'm always trying to figure out how to take care of myself, selfcare. Reading comments that are intended to be nothing other than cruel and unkind is not good for my psyche on a daily basis. Howe

reporter speaking

Oh my goodness, yeah yeah, I've had many days where I call them ??? where I'm just like con, just it's really hard and um, but what I wanted to say was I else I also got some useful critical feedback that I wouldn't have got I wouldn't have maybe heard if I hadn't been engaging in that way and engaging in that space and I saw the white feminism coming up again and again and I was like this is clearly something that I have to meaningfully engage with I have I I have to understand this better I want to understand it better and ehm, you know I have ??? as well as I know I found her book *Why I'm no longer talking to white people about race*

reporter speaking

It just it did! Yeah, yeah.

reporter speaking

And it put it all in one place in one space in a really clearly defined narrative and exploration. The journey really started when I went to university in the States, when you study history you're given source A, source B, source C, compare the sources, compare the validity of the sources etc and so like you kind of do those as as like exercises but to actually sit in another country and hear your history told differently to how you have been taught it at home and I remember sitting in my lecture hall and you know listening listening to my professor and genuinely turning around in the middle of my ??? and I'm like is anyone else having some kind of breakdown here? Because it felt so just it was the first time I had had a first-hand experience of of realizing oh my goodness, history is genuinely told from the perspective of who it's told by and so I think really the biggest thing I took from Ronnie's book was the desperate need to reform our education system in the UK and the way that we tell the story of how we have been involved in foreign affairs in our relationship to slavery ehm

reporter speaking

Which we never talk about!

reporter speaking

We never talk about it. And it's not okay, it's just like deeply, deeply, deeply not okay. I had really considered myself to be well-read and I have a university degree and I the label of my

university degree and it just suddenly it felt not meaningless or anything like that, but it felt like this needs critical analysis. What I've learned, who I've read and why I've been told to read it, who's been included, who hasn't, whose voices are missing

reporter speaking

And it kind of set me off on a whole track of ??? you know looking at everything I heard, everything I'd learnt, so it was a real I mean it was awakening and

Appendix 2

Appendix 2 involves a transcript of an interview with Speaker 2, Boris Johnson for the British morning show *This Morning* broadcast on ITV. The transcript starts at 0:00 and continues until 8:14. Three question marks in a row symbolize an unidentifiable word.

reporter speaking

Good morning, good morning.

reporter speaking

No not at all. Let me let me clear that up immediately. Because it's very important that we are transparent, people understand that we're transparent, ou, public health England needs to be absolutely sure about the diagnosis of these cases, so what they're doing is they're immediately identifying the the region, where they think there's a an incidence and then within 24 hours confirming the exact location to be sure that we've got the right thing.

reporter speaking

And because we're building up a map, a proper database that the public can access showing the whole thing in real time.

reporter speaking

No, I really...

reporter speaking

Absolutely.

reporter speaking

No, I mean...

reporter speaking

Exact, and I think one of the great things about the British public is they can, can see very, we can all see very clearly what the balance of risk is. We can, we can see, where this is happening and the rate at which it's spreading so I'm with you. And we're putting it all out there and that's a...

reporter speaking

Exactly.

reporter speaking

Yes, we're on the on the specific incident, so the where individuals get it as you know that the confirmed cases at the moment of ??? at 85. We're putting it out as fast as we as

we can that's what we want to do, we want to communicate, overcommunicate with the public about what is what is happening. It's worth, it's always worth stressing with this that for the overwhelming majority of people this is gonna be, who get it. This is gonna be a mild to moderate illness and, you know it, we're still at the stage where the single best thing we can do, and we'll be like that for a long time, right, it's just wash our hands!

reporter speaking

Well, it's for 20 seconds.

reporter speaking

Hot water.

reporter speaking

I've just now...

reporter speaking

I did.

reporter speaking

I did, I did, I did like and I go, that's right, and I I went, I've been going around hospitals, as you can imagine, and I I I think you always always shake hands and, you know, people make their own decisions but ee washing them is the single most effective thing rather than sort of barring all forms.

reporter speaking

I washed my hands.

reporter speaking

I vice to everybody, wash your hands at all times.

reporter speaking

Yes.

reporter speaking

Let me explain exactly, let me explain, what, what, what's happening today. So as people know, the numbers continue to to grow I mean not exponentially but they're continuing to to grow. So the scientific advisory group for emergencies sage is is meeting and they will consider a a range of options that we have to try to delay the the spread and, you know, they range from things like, you know, stopping big public gatherings, sporting gatherings ad so on, closing schools that sort of thing quite ??? stuff...

reporter speaking

To to to to more targeted interventions which would be really helping the other things.

reporter speaking

To protect themselves.

reporter speaking

So, well, we'll see what the scientists advise, it's the best thing. I find it, you know, these guys are brilliant. They're epidemiologists who understand behavioural psychology of the population and they understand how these things spread. So we'll gonna see, what they, what they say but just for your guidance and for everybody to think about, at the moment, what they're, what they're telling me is that actually slightly country intuitively ee things like closing schools and stopping big gatherings don't work as well perhaps as as people think in stopping the spread that's what they're saying to me at the moment. So our advice on school closures remains pretty much where it was, I mean exactly where it was, which is that we don't think at the moment that schools should be closing but unless, of course, there is an incidence in the ??? there are cases in school in the school in which case they should obviously talk to the public health England.

reporter speaking

It's a very very important question and ee that's where a lot of the debate has been. And the one of the theories is that, you know, perhaps you could sort of take it on the ??? take it all in one, in one go and allow the disease as if it were to to move through the population. I, without really taking as many draconian measures, I think we need to strike a balance. I think it's very important, we got a fantastic NHS. We'll give them all the support that they need. We'll make sure that they have all the preparations, all the kit that they need to for us to get through it. But I think it would be better, I we take all the measures that we can now just to, you know, to stop the peak of the disease being as as ee difficult for the NHS as it was I think there are things that we may be able to do.

reporter speaking

Well, I mean if, you know, I don't want to get into a ??? of course of greatly increase the number of nurses in the NHS are many more than they were in 2010, for instance.

reporter speaking

But, but, but you're right and that's why we're recruiting 50 000 more...

reporter speaking

Well, I'm gonna, I'm not gonna disagree with you. I mean you're right and ee but we're going as fast as we possibly can. Remember, we shortened the visa application process we've restored the bursary for nurses so that, you know, the real incentives now to get into in nurse and in in the course of the next few weeks we will really do everything to make sure that the NHS is able to ???.